central Myanmar, and from there to the Indian border. It is uncertain, however, whether China's security services are directly involved in this traffic, or if the weapons have been obtained on the Chinese black market. In any case, this has always been a grey area. When he is not paying occasional visits to Taka, ULFA commander-in-chief Paresh Baruah is based in Yunnan.

Baruah's presence in Yunnan and involvement with the 2004 Chittagong shipment, which although done through 'private arms dealers', was of such a quantity that it would have been impossible to conduct without at least the tacit approval of influential people, show that China's security services have not severed links with insurgents of northeastern India, and the relationship clearly goes beyond commercial deals. As long as the Dalai Lama and his Tibetan government in exile are based in India, China is not likely to give up those connections, which could be used simply to annoy India or, more specifically, for maintaining leverage inside India for purposes such as influencing border talks and other bilateral issues.

Bhutan is only a small pawn in this game, but not an unimportant one for China. While Mao Zedong once held that Bhutan should be part of China, Beijing settled for a different approach after Bhutan had joined the UN in 1971. The CIA analysed China's renewed interest in a 1975 report on Chinese-Indian relations. 'Not only was it meant to explore the possibility of increasing Bhutanese restlessness under Indian tutelage, but also to demonstrate, albeit in a low-key way, China's interest in preserving the status of Bhutan as a buffer between China and India.'[49]

Bhutan, along with India, voted in favour of the People's Republic of China taking over the China seat from the Republic of China in the UN in 1971. With Thimphu and Beijing both now having representatives at the UN headquarters in New York, direct contact between the two countries could begin. And the first major event that brought China into the equation with Bhutan was the coronation of Jigme Singye Wangchuk. Although he had been king since 1972, the coronation had to wait for an auspicious date chosen by astrologers. On 2 June 1974, the Raven Crown was bestowed upon the fourth druk gyalpo at a ceremony attended, among other dignitaries, by Ma Muming, chargé d'affaires at the Chinese embassy in New Delhi. Ma's visit was described by China's official news agency Xinhua as 'a new page in the friendly contacts between the two countries'.[50] The Chinese congratulatory message emphasized the 'desire